

Stegosaurus

The woodlands of the Jurassic Period teemed with massive, four-legged plant-eaters called stegosaurus. Members of the stegosaur family often had defensive spikes on their tails and shoulders, and rows of bony plates ran along their backs. The purpose of the plates is a mystery, but they may have been used for display or temperature control.

▼ SPIKES

Each shoulder had a large spike. Pairs of smaller spikes lined the tail. The spikes probably helped ward off attackers.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Double row of plates or spikes along the neck, back, and tail
- Narrow head
- Beaklike tip of mouth
- Hooflike toes
- Walked on all fours

When

Stegosaurus lived from 176 million years ago (Middle Jurassic) to 100 million years ago (Early Cretaceous).

Stegosaurus

STEG-oh-SORE-uss



- **When** 150–145 million years ago (Late Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** USA, Portugal
- **Habitat** Woodland
- **Length** 30 ft (9 m)
- **Diet** Plants

Large, diamond-shaped plates ran along the back of this famous dinosaur. Although the plates would have made *Stegosaurus* look bigger and more fearsome, they were no good as armor. It's more likely they evolved for use in social or courtship displays. *Stegosaurus* had a toothless beak made of a hornlike substance. At the back of its mouth were rows of teeth that it used to crush leaves, chewing them to a pulp with simple up-and-down movements.

Each plate was covered with a tough, hornlike layer or skin.

The hindlimb was twice as long as the forelimb.